

Vertigo



(by David Owen, Near the summit of Double Cone)

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club - Wellington Section

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Section News

Section Nights

Our April section night is at 6pm on 6 April at the Southern Cross Garden Bar, 39 Abel Smith Street.

We are having a double billing that night with Leigh Matheson from the Met Service coming along to present on weather followed by Ric Cullinane from Walking Access presenting to us on the role of Walking Access and information about their mapping service.

The other highlight of the evening is that we're bringing along a select few books from our library collection that you'll be able to browse and then borrow as well as a range of books / magazines that will be up for sale for a very nominal price.

Come along, invite your friends and grab a drink from the bar – there'll be time for a catch up and chat after the meeting.

Chair's Report

A stunning kick off for the first quarter of the year with packed section nights and fully subscribed courses. I hope you have all been able to make the most of the warm rock this summer and got in some enjoyable and memorable climbs. Who knows what the winter will bring but we aren't waiting to find out and have locked in our course dates early this year. See details in this edition of Vertigo.

The committee has been busy planning trips, selecting Banff films and securing entertaining, enlightening and exuberant speakers for our section nights. Next week, due to unprecedented popular demand, we have another double billing with the Met Service severe weather forecaster Leigh Matheson to give you a heads up on how to do your own forecasting when you're out of cell phone range and Ric Cullinane from Walking Access fame to share the secrets of mapping New Zealand and how to get in and out of places you didn't even know existed. If that isn't enough, I'll be there too and can show you my legs which have been doing battle with onga onga, cutting grass, spaniards, bush lawyer, wasps, matagouri and the ubiquitous bastard hook grass while I've been pottering around in the garden.

For something more family oriented, we are planning a section trip to Tukino over the first weekend of the April school holidays (15th to 17th April) to do some old routes, put in some new routes and generally let the kids and adults (though I'm yet to work out the difference) run free in the climbing wonderland. More details on that trip due out shortly.

Simon

For quick access to the section’s page on the NZAC website, scan the below QR code.



Upcoming Trips, Courses and Events

Wellington Section Trips

The following are trips that are being planned by the committee. The section will be subsidising rental vehicles for the South Island trips to make the trips more affordable. Keep an eye on our Facebook page for more details or email us on wellington@alpineclub.org.nz to let us know. Also, please contact us if you're keen to run a trip yourself.

When?	Where?
April 15-17	Rock climbing at Tukino – suitable for families and anyone who is keen for some rock climbing before the routes get covered in snow.
Anzac Weekend	Hopkins Valley – climbing Dasler Pinnacles / Rabbiters Peak
Queen's Birthday Weekend	Seaward Kaikouras
August 25-28	Remarkables Ice and Mixed Festival

Wellington Section Snowcraft courses

Beginner course:

- moving on snow using ice axe and crampons
- evaluating terrain for safe travel
- navigation
- avalanche transceiver use

This course focuses on taking participants new to mountaineering into the mountains to gain skills, confidence and experience in the alpine environment. It requires good fitness and caters to those with little or no experience on snow or ice. It involves learning the basics of moving around in alpine terrain safely, using an ice axe and crampons, identifying terrain hazards and basic emergency procedures. It does not include ropes. It assumes prior knowledge of tramping and self management in a remote environment. It does not assume prior knowledge of alpine skills.

Intermediate course:

- using ropes & snow anchors

This course builds on the competencies of a beginner, adding rope, anchors and belays and single pitch climbing. The course assumes prior knowledge of core snow craft skills such as cramponing, transceiver searches, ice axe use and self management in a remote alpine environment.

Advanced course:

- pitching and travel

This course focuses on consolidation of the skills covered in the beginner and intermediate courses and applying them to pitched climbing and travel in an alpine environment.

Course Dates

22-24 July (pre-course evening 14 July); split Beginner and Intermediate course

12-24 August (pre-course evening 4 August) split Beginner and Intermediate course.

26-28 August (pre-course evening 18 August) Advanced course.

All pre-course evenings are in Wellington at Bivouac on the Thursday night a week prior at 6pm.

Courses are held at the Tukino lodge on Mt Ruapehu and include accommodation for two nights, main meals and transport from the two wheel drive car park. The section provides selected equipment for hire (except boots, clothing and personal items) for \$5 an item per 7 days.

The course fee is \$250. You need to be a member of the NZAC to attend our snowcraft courses. See <http://alpineclub.org.nz/apply-for-membership/> for details on how to signup to the NZAC. There is a \$100 deposit payable on registration. This deposit is refundable up to a week prior to the start date of the course after which the deposit is forfeited.

Registration forms will be available on Facebook and on our section page of the NZAC website very soon.

Trip Reports

High Alpine Skills Course – 5 – 10 January 2016

Words and pictures by David Owen

In early January this year, a friend and I joined a pair of Christchurch climbing enthusiasts and a Wanaka based guide for the Alpine Club's week long High Alpine Skills Course at Aoraki/Mt Cook. The course structure and content is designed to be as responsive to the climbing skills and goals of the participants as possible so we were excited, and somewhat nervous, to see how we compared against the other blokes, and whether the instructor would be horrified or humoured at our previous climbs given our current level of "skills". We needn't have worried as George and Andy turned out to be great blokes at a similar level and instructor Tim did well to thwart our frequent attempts to abseil with unlocked screw gates and hide any disdain he had for our climbing exploits. The Course itself was a great time, we learned lots, and I would recommend anyone considering it to sign up. I briefly recount my experience below.

Alpine Trad and Climbing Routes

After choppering into Barron Saddle from Mt Cook Airport on a fine Tuesday morning, and a lunch time discussion about where we should camp that night, we made our way to a bivvy spot a few hundred meters below Barron Saddle Hut, overlooking the upper Mueller Glacier. Following a pleasant night under the stars, and a duel with a family of kea over breakfast, we set out for our first climbing objective – Mt Darby. The route involved some steep snow slopes, a bit of glacier travel, and a reasonably lengthy trad route along an exposed ridge. Under the watchful eye of Tim, we placed and pulled gear, led and belayed, and operated running belays on routes and lines of our choosing up to the peak. We abseiled off the other side of the summit and descended a fairly steep and awfully soft snow slope before having a late lunch and debrief about the morning. My mate (also a Dave) and I were chuffed with the morning's efforts – although we had climbed the likes of Aspiring and Brewster before, we were rather under done on the trad skills and placing gear front. With Tim's help, we could now see where we needed to improve and gained some valuable skills to take forward – all inside the first full day.



[The author on the summit of Mt Darby. Mt Sealy, the Sealy range, and ultimately Mt Cook Village behind]

Bivvying and weather assessment

As discussed on our morning of departure, the plan for the trip was to spend as much of the week as possible camping out in either tents or bivvy bags. The first night went to plan with our carefully constructed bivvy spots (lined with the flattest alpine schist) providing a restful night for the team. However, as we sat around debriefing after the Darby climb, it was increasingly apparent our bivvying for the trip was over. While it remained sunny, the morning's breeze had gradually turned into a gale and there was a growing need to reassess plans. Accordingly, we retreated to Barron Saddle Hut, put on a brew and awaited the 7pm forecast over the mountain radio. The news wasn't good – the wind was forecast to increase in intensity, the freezing level was dropping, and a mix of snow showers and heavy rain was expected throughout the area for the remainder of the week. In the discussions that followed, we all agreed that the best approach was to break trail early the next morning, climb over the Sealy Range and descend to Mueller Hut. That way we could avoid the worst of what was to come, get a good day of high alpine glacier travel in beforehand, and be in a better position to take advantage of any weather windows that might develop in the coming days, rather than being hut bound in the confines of the Barron Saddle tin can.



[The Bivvy Spot – below Barron Saddle, overlooking the upper Mueller and out towards Vampire]

Glacier Travel and Crevasse rescue

We set off in the dark on the morning of the third day with a good freeze underfoot but foreboding skies overhead, and wasted no time in partially retracing our steps back towards Mt Sealy. In doing so, we navigated through a number of crevasse systems, and down climbed a long, steep and rather unpleasant snow slope at the top of the Sealy Glacier as the wind really began to hum and skies darken. It wasn't all doom and gloom however, as Tim continued to educate us about potential hazards, constructively questioned our glacier travel techniques, and confided in us some of his secrets for efficiently transitioning between different modes of alpine travel. After the heavy downpours had ceased we spent our fourth day perfecting the mechanics of weighted crevasse rescue on a snow slope behind Muller Hut. When they and the snow showers returned however, we were forced to retreat into the Hut where a diverse group of climbers and day walkers were treated to a series of prussic races, up a full 50m length of rope gradually let out as the climber neared the rafters. While not so glamorous, the time spent both putting in the crevasse rescue systems and sweating through the prussic challenge reinforced a number of skills that are rarely used but are crucially important to have in the hills.



[Glacier travel beneath a brooding Aoraki]

Multi Pitch Rock

For our final day, we decided to descend to the valley floor and head for the well-known crags of Sebastopol, a few minutes' walk from the Alpine Club's Mt Cook base, Unwin Lodge. There, with our improved rope, lead climbing, belay, and gear management techniques we spend an enjoyable day multi-pitch climbing in fair weather. As with the trad climbing earlier in the week, Dave and I really benefited from a good day of it in the field with Tim on hand to answer any questions, suggested improvements, and close screw gates as required.



[Gearing up for a rock pitch]

Overall, I thoroughly enjoyed the week and learned far more than I have conveyed here. It was a great experience, in a special part of our high country, and I really recommend people consider enrolling on a course next summer. I would like to thank the Alpine Club for putting on the course, George and Andy for the good times, and Tim Steward for sharing all his knowledge.



[From left to right: George, Andy, Dave, Tim, and Dave (the author) at Sealy Tarns part way down from Mueller Hut.]

Wellington Section 2016 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Contact
Chairperson	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
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Any media queries should be directed to:		
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* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.



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